

PATHSEEKER CAREER PASSPORT

High-Impact Portfolio Guide for Tech and Design

Turn projects into concise evidence of how you frame problems, make decisions, collaborate, and improve outcomes.

BEST FOR

Designers, developers, analysts, and career changers building an early-career portfolio.

FORMAT

9-page guide and review checklist - write directly on a printed copy or duplicate the prompts into your notes app.

Discover what fits you best - then test it with evidence.

01 - PURPOSE

Design for a real reviewer

A portfolio is an evidence interface. Decide what role it supports and what a busy reviewer should remember after two minutes.

Target role and market...

Three capabilities I need to prove...

Can this person solve our kind of problem?	
Can they explain decisions?	
Can they finish and learn?	
Can they collaborate responsibly?	

02 - SELECT

Choose fewer, stronger projects

Two or three deep projects usually communicate more than a gallery of unfinished exercises.

- ☐ The problem is understandable without insider knowledge.
- ☐ My contribution is distinct from the team's work.
- ☐ I can show decisions, not just a final screen or codebase.
- ☐ The project includes constraints or tradeoffs.
- ☐ I can discuss what changed after feedback.

03 - STORY

Use a case-study spine

Make the sequence easy to scan. Put the most important evidence close to the claim it supports.

Snapshot	Problem, outcome, timeframe, team, and my role
Context	Who was affected and why the problem mattered
Constraints	Time, data, policy, technology, or access limits
Process	Only the steps that changed a decision
Evidence	Research, tests, metrics, code, or analysis
Outcome	Measured result or the honest next validation step
Reflection	What I would do differently and why

My case study in one sentence...

04 - REASONING

Show decisions and tradeoffs

Artifacts matter when you explain what they helped you decide.

- ☐ I explain why an option was rejected.
- ☐ I distinguish assumptions from validated findings.
- ☐ I name uncertainty and limitations.
- ☐ I credit collaborators and sources.
- ☐ I avoid claiming impact I cannot verify.

05 - OUTCOMES

Make impact credible

Use the strongest evidence available and label its quality. A learning result can be honest and valuable even without business metrics.

Measured outcome	Task completion improved from a tested baseline
Behavior signal	Users completed the key flow in a moderated test
Delivery evidence	Feature shipped with tests and documentation
Stakeholder decision	Analysis changed scope or priority
Learning evidence	Experiment invalidated an assumption and informed the next step

My strongest outcome claim, its source, and its limitation...

06 - PRESENTATION

Build an accessible experience

A polished portfolio respects readers using keyboards, zoom, screen readers, low-bandwidth devices, and small screens.

- ☐ Pages use one descriptive H1 and logical headings.
- ☐ Images have useful alt text or are marked decorative.
- ☐ Color contrast is sufficient and color is not the only signal.
- ☐ Focus states are visible and order is logical.
- ☐ Links describe their destination.
- ☐ Video has captions or a transcript.
- ☐ Text remains usable at 200% zoom.
- ☐ Large media is optimized and lazy-loaded.
- ☐ A PDF resume remains selectable text.

Test

Navigate the entire portfolio with only Tab, Shift+Tab, Enter, and Escape. Then test at a narrow mobile width.

07 - FOR DEVELOPERS AND ANALYSTS

Technical portfolio signals

A repository should help another person understand, run, and evaluate the work safely.

- ☐ README states the problem and target user.
- ☐ Setup steps work from a clean clone.
- ☐ Secrets and personal data are excluded.
- ☐ Sample environment variables are documented.
- ☐ Architecture choices and tradeoffs are explained.
- ☐ Tests cover the most important behavior.
- ☐ Known limitations are honest.
- ☐ Screenshots or a live demo show the result.
- ☐ Commit history or changelog shows iteration.

The technical decision I am most ready to defend...

08 - FINAL GATE

Publish and improve

Ask reviewers to evaluate specific capabilities, not whether they generally like the portfolio.

Role relevance	Which capability is clearest or missing?	
Story clarity	Where did you lose the thread?	
Evidence	Which claim needs stronger support?	
Usability	What was hard to find or use?	
Credibility	What would you ask in an interview?	

Sources and responsible use

U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics - Occupational Outlook Handbook

Occupation duties, education, 2024 pay, and 2024-2034 outlook reference data.

<https://www.bls.gov/ooh/>

O*NET OnLine

Detailed occupation tasks, knowledge, skills, work activities, and technology examples.

<https://www.onetonline.org/>

CareerOneStop

Career exploration, training, job-search, and local salary research tools.

<https://www.careeronestop.org/>

W3C Web Accessibility Initiative

Accessibility standards, tutorials, and evaluation techniques.

<https://www.w3.org/WAI/>

Important

Career requirements, salaries, and hiring practices vary by country, city, employer, experience, and economic conditions. Use occupational data as a research starting point, not a promise of employment or pay.